BLANKS ON THE MAP

THE BOUNDARY

Even today, almost seventy years after Independence, when we talk of the northeastern part of India or the trans-Himalayan regions of Jammu and Kashmir, these vital and integral parts of India are blanks on the map of our collective consciousness. In the 1950s and 1960s, India not only had a leadership that was fairly clueless about geopolitical affairs, its armed forces, which it had inherited from the British, were also in a state of limbo. During World War II, various regiments of the Indian Army had earned their spurs in modern warfare and emerged with enhanced reputations. However, even though the Indianization of the armed forces had begun, the seniormost officers at the time had hardly even commanded infantry battalions, with just one or two having made brigadier by the time the war ended.

Being thrown into a conflict over Kashmir with Pakistan almost immediately, the obvious shortcomings did not show up, partly because the other side had similar problems and the two sides fought each other using similar tactics. When the Communist Party under Mao came to power in 1949 in China after defeating the Nationalist Chinese, it almost immediately annexed both Sinkiang and Tibet. Almost overnight, the military equation on the border changed dramatically, but the Indians failed to grasp the impact it would have on the subcontinent's security. As events unfolded over the next decade, they failed to understand not only China's long-term geopolitical ambitions, which were blatantly expansionist, they also severely underestimated China's operational capabilities.

On the Indian side, the decade-long build-up to 1962 coincided with the somewhat one-sided power struggle that would define civil-military relations in India. Nehru's own insecurities vis-à-vis the generals, combined with the absurd posturing that a non-violent nation did not really need an army, created a situation where the Indian Army was almost leaderless and